

A CASTE MULTITUDE The scene from a political rally in Lucknow

THE BJP-LED UNION GOVERNMENT HAS PERFORMED a stunning pivot on the question of the caste census. After years of remaining ambivalent on the issue—and even deriding the idea as divisive—Prime Minister Narendra Modi's government now says it will enumerate the nation's myriad castes in the much delayed decadal census. The unexpected turn is the result of a complex interplay of issues—electoral calculus, state-level pressures and a recognition that caste realities can no longer be ignored, even for a party that built its brand on the promise of a 'casteless' Hindutva nationalism. There's also a bevy of state elections coming up, most importantly in Bihar, where being on the right side of the caste cohort debate could pay rich dividends. Indeed, many see the caste survey as a political gamble aimed at outflanking Mandal-era parties on their home turf, blunting the Congress's social justice pitch, and recasting the BJP as the new custodian of the Bahujan *samaj*.

For decades, the BJP avoided taking a stand on caste-based enumeration. While leaders like the late Gopinath Munde, a prominent OBC voice from Maharashtra, had made a compelling case in Parliament in 2011, the party remained non-committal. This despite many in Modi's cabinet, the BJP and the Sangh's *samarasta* (social harmony) *manch* backing it. In 2021, the government also reiterated in both Parliament and the Supreme Court that it would not undertake such a census.

BJP sources say PM Modi's 'framework' divides Indians into four broad groups—the poor, the youth, women and farmers—not caste categories. Moreover, the BJP's lack of urgency on sub-categorising the OBCs (Other Backward Classes)—even after the Rohini Commission report in 2023—spoke of its reluctance to disturb the status quo of its social coalition. In October 2023, BJP Union ministers, including Kiren Rijiju, even warned that the Congress and Rahul Gandhi's call for "*jitni aabaadi, utna haq* (rights proportional to population)" would "kill India", arguing it would pit larger populations against smaller ones and harm national unity. PM Modi himself, from the rally stages, accused the Congress of "playing with fire", and questioned if proportional rights meant sidelining minorities or the southern states. That the very same BJP now touts a caste census as a progressive step is a "dramatic U-turn", according to the Opposition.

MANDAL 2.0, MODI-STYLE

Yet, it is also true that the BJP of today is a far cry from the upper caste bastion it was during the 1990s Mandal years. Modi, an OBC himself, has worked assiduously to dismantle the BJP's image of being a Brahmin-Bania-Rajput party, expanding Hindutva's appeal across caste lines. Many within the Sangh Parivar now argue that accepting the caste census is a natural extension of this journey.

To understand the BJP's shift in stand, one has to revisit the resurgence of Mandal-era politics in recent years. The term 'Mandal 2.0' captures the renewed drive for caste-based social justice, reminiscent of the early '90s, when the implementation of OBC reservations reshaped Indian politics. Ahead of the 2024 general election, the Opposition, led by the Congress and regional forces like the Samajwadi Party (SP) and Rashtriya Janata Dal (RJD), revived the debate on caste inequality. They had a pointed message: if the OBCs and other disadvantaged groups make up the majority, why are they so poorly represented? They pledged a national caste census and a policy overhaul based on its findings, including expanding the 50 per cent reservation cap in education and jobs set by the Supreme Court. By late 2023, the issue gathered momentum. Bihar had completed a caste survey, Karnataka revisited its long-pending caste report, and Congress-ruled Rajasthan and Chhattisgarh were actively considering similar exercises.

It was a direct challenge to the BJP, which had largely shaped it political discourse around religion (Hindus vs others) and nationalism rather than caste identity in the past decade. Initially, the BJP tried to counter the narrative by painting